So I was surprised when father insisted on accompanying me to the college on the first day. The college buildings were still under construction and outstation students were given some rented houses on the outskirts as hostels. After the first-day formalities at the college, father came with me to the hostel—a small house with the number 'A31' at Thiru Nagar about three kilometer from the campus. After depositing me and the bags, father held my hand and started crying.

It was the second time I was seeing him in tears—the first was when his mother, my grandmother, died. I could not fathom the emotional turmoil I was going through. I felt myself choking while trying to stop myself from crying. I never thought my father and I shared such a bond. I suddenly felt I would be too lonely without my father's silent presence.

'Take care of your health, study well,' he said, and walked away.

I stood there at the gate even after he disappeared around the bend of the road. I felt a vacuum within. Five months later, I would be standing here again, on a rainy night, to receive a telegram from home.

On that November night, when the rain came down in sheets, I lay awake as if expecting the bad news. When the postman clanked the gate around 3.30 am, I opened the door as if it was all pre-progammed. I walked up to the gate as if in a trance and took the telegram. Before opening it I knew the content. The telegram read: FATHER SERIOUS. START IMMEDIATELY. The crumpled paper with the black telegraphic letters was wet. It must have been the rain. Or my tears.

I do not remember packing anything, I just walked out of the hostel with whatever little money I had. A goods truck took me to Tirunelveli from where I took a bus to Nagercoil. My house was still some distance away. I walked to the place of Shanmugham, a news agent I knew in Nagercoil. He was not there. I took his bicycle and pedalled home.

A cousin saw me coming and took me inside the house. My father was lying unconscious. The cousin briefed me that father had suffered a heart attack the previous day and the family had taken him to Dr Seetharaman in Trivandrum. Father had slipped into a coma, and that is when they sent me